

ZERO-BASED BUDGET WORKBOOK

Give Every Dollar a Job

12 Months of Zero-Based Budgeting Templates

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WHAT IS ZERO-BASED BUDGETING?

Zero-based budgeting means: $\text{INCOME} - \text{EXPENSES} = \0

Every single dollar has a job. Nothing is left 'floating around' without a purpose. This doesn't mean you spend everything - savings and debt payoff ARE jobs for your dollars.

THE FORMULA:

$\text{Total Income} - \text{Total Expenses} - \text{Savings} - \text{Giving} = \0

WHY IT WORKS:

- You tell your money where to go instead of wondering where it went
- You make spending decisions BEFORE the month, not during
- Every dollar is intentional
- You catch overspending immediately
- You prioritize what matters most

HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK:

1. Calculate your total monthly income
2. List ALL expenses by category
3. Assign dollars to each category until you hit \$0
4. Track actual spending throughout the month
5. Adjust next month based on what you learn

RULES:

- Do the budget BEFORE the month starts
- Both partners must agree (if applicable)
- Adjust mid-month if needed (life happens)
- The goal is progress, not perfection

INCOME CALCULATION WORKSHEET

List ALL sources of income (use TAKE-HOME pay, after taxes):

REGULAR INCOME:

Job 1 (paycheck 1): \$_____ Frequency: _____

Job 1 (paycheck 2): \$_____ Frequency: _____

Job 2: \$_____ Frequency: _____

Spouse/Partner income: \$_____ Frequency: _____

ADDITIONAL INCOME:

Side hustle/freelance: \$_____

Child support/alimony: \$_____

Government benefits: \$_____

Rental income: \$_____

Other: \$_____

TOTAL MONTHLY INCOME: \$_____

IF IRREGULAR INCOME:

Use your LOWEST month from the past 6 months as your baseline.

Lowest month was: \$_____

If you earn more, put extra toward savings/debt first.

FIXED & VARIABLE EXPENSES

FIXED EXPENSES (same every month):

Rent/Mortgage: \$_____
Car payment: \$_____
Insurance (auto): \$_____
Insurance (health): \$_____
Phone: \$_____
Internet: \$_____
Subscriptions: \$_____
Childcare/tuition: \$_____
Minimum debt payments: \$_____
Other fixed: \$_____
TOTAL FIXED: \$_____

VARIABLE EXPENSES (change monthly):

Groceries: \$_____
Gas/Transportation: \$_____
Utilities (electric/gas/water): \$_____
Eating out: \$_____
Entertainment: \$_____
Clothing: \$_____
Personal care: \$_____
Household items: \$_____
TOTAL VARIABLE: \$_____

SINKING FUNDS PLANNER

Sinking funds = saving monthly for expenses that come periodically.

ANNUAL/IRREGULAR EXPENSES: Total Monthly Set-Aside

Car registration/inspection: \$____ \$____ / 12 = \$____

Car maintenance/repairs: \$____ \$____ / 12 = \$____

Christmas/holidays: \$____ \$____ / 12 = \$____

Birthdays: \$____ \$____ / 12 = \$____

Back to school: \$____ \$____ / 12 = \$____

Home maintenance: \$____ \$____ / 12 = \$____

Medical (copays, dental): \$____ \$____ / 12 = \$____

Vacation: \$____ \$____ / 12 = \$____

Annual subscriptions: \$____ \$____ / 12 = \$____

Property taxes (if not escrowed): \$____ \$____ / 12 = \$____

Pet expenses: \$____ \$____ / 12 = \$____

Other: _____ \$____ \$____ / 12 = \$____

TOTAL SINKING FUNDS MONTHLY: \$_____

Keep sinking funds in a separate savings account.

Label them! (Many banks allow sub-accounts or use envelopes.)

JANUARY ZERO-BASED BUDGET

INCOME: \$ _____

GIVING/TITHE:

Tithe: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Charity: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

SAVINGS:

Emergency fund: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Sinking funds: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Retirement: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

HOUSING:

Rent/Mortgage: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Utilities: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Phone/Internet: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

FOOD:

Groceries: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Eating out: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TRANSPORTATION:

Gas: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Car payment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Insurance: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

INSURANCE:

Health: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Life: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

PERSONAL:

Clothing: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Personal care: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Entertainment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

DEBT:

Credit card: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Student loan: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Other: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TOTAL EXPENSES: \$ _____ **INCOME - EXPENSES =** \$ _____ (should be \$0)

FEBRUARY ZERO-BASED BUDGET

INCOME: \$ _____

GIVING/TITHE:

Tithe: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Charity: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

SAVINGS:

Emergency fund: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Sinking funds: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Retirement: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

HOUSING:

Rent/Mortgage: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Utilities: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Phone/Internet: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

FOOD:

Groceries: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Eating out: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TRANSPORTATION:

Gas: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Car payment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Insurance: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

INSURANCE:

Health: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Life: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

PERSONAL:

Clothing: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Personal care: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Entertainment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

DEBT:

Credit card: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Student loan: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Other: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TOTAL EXPENSES: \$ _____ **INCOME - EXPENSES =** \$ _____ (should be \$0)

MARCH ZERO-BASED BUDGET

INCOME: \$ _____

GIVING/TITHE:

Tithe: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Charity: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

SAVINGS:

Emergency fund: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Sinking funds: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Retirement: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

HOUSING:

Rent/Mortgage: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Utilities: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Phone/Internet: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

FOOD:

Groceries: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Eating out: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TRANSPORTATION:

Gas: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Car payment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Insurance: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

INSURANCE:

Health: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Life: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

PERSONAL:

Clothing: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Personal care: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Entertainment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

DEBT:

Credit card: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Student loan: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Other: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TOTAL EXPENSES: \$ _____ **INCOME - EXPENSES =** \$ _____ (should be \$0)

APRIL ZERO-BASED BUDGET

INCOME: \$ _____

GIVING/TITHE:

Tithe: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Charity: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

SAVINGS:

Emergency fund: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Sinking funds: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Retirement: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

HOUSING:

Rent/Mortgage: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Utilities: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Phone/Internet: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

FOOD:

Groceries: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Eating out: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TRANSPORTATION:

Gas: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Car payment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Insurance: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

INSURANCE:

Health: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Life: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

PERSONAL:

Clothing: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Personal care: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Entertainment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

DEBT:

Credit card: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Student loan: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Other: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TOTAL EXPENSES: \$ _____ **INCOME - EXPENSES =** \$ _____ (should be \$0)

MAY ZERO-BASED BUDGET

INCOME: \$ _____

GIVING/TITHE:

Tithe: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Charity: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

SAVINGS:

Emergency fund: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Sinking funds: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Retirement: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

HOUSING:

Rent/Mortgage: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Utilities: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Phone/Internet: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

FOOD:

Groceries: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Eating out: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TRANSPORTATION:

Gas: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Car payment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Insurance: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

INSURANCE:

Health: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Life: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

PERSONAL:

Clothing: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Personal care: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Entertainment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

DEBT:

Credit card: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Student loan: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Other: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TOTAL EXPENSES: \$ _____ **INCOME - EXPENSES =** \$ _____ (should be \$0)

JUNE ZERO-BASED BUDGET

INCOME: \$ _____

GIVING/TITHE:

Tithe: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Charity: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

SAVINGS:

Emergency fund: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Sinking funds: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Retirement: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

HOUSING:

Rent/Mortgage: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Utilities: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Phone/Internet: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

FOOD:

Groceries: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Eating out: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TRANSPORTATION:

Gas: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Car payment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Insurance: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

INSURANCE:

Health: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Life: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

PERSONAL:

Clothing: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Personal care: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Entertainment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

DEBT:

Credit card: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Student loan: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Other: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TOTAL EXPENSES: \$ _____ **INCOME - EXPENSES =** \$ _____ (should be \$0)

JULY ZERO-BASED BUDGET

INCOME: \$ _____

GIVING/TITHE:

Tithe: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Charity: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

SAVINGS:

Emergency fund: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Sinking funds: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Retirement: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

HOUSING:

Rent/Mortgage: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Utilities: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Phone/Internet: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

FOOD:

Groceries: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Eating out: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TRANSPORTATION:

Gas: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Car payment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Insurance: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

INSURANCE:

Health: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Life: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

PERSONAL:

Clothing: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Personal care: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Entertainment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

DEBT:

Credit card: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Student loan: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Other: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TOTAL EXPENSES: \$ _____ **INCOME - EXPENSES =** \$ _____ (should be \$0)

AUGUST ZERO-BASED BUDGET

INCOME: \$ _____

GIVING/TITHE:

Tithe: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Charity: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

SAVINGS:

Emergency fund: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Sinking funds: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Retirement: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

HOUSING:

Rent/Mortgage: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Utilities: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Phone/Internet: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

FOOD:

Groceries: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Eating out: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TRANSPORTATION:

Gas: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Car payment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Insurance: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

INSURANCE:

Health: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Life: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

PERSONAL:

Clothing: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Personal care: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Entertainment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

DEBT:

Credit card: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Student loan: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Other: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TOTAL EXPENSES: \$ _____ **INCOME - EXPENSES =** \$ _____ (should be \$0)

SEPTEMBER ZERO-BASED BUDGET

INCOME: \$ _____

GIVING/TITHE:

Tithe: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Charity: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

SAVINGS:

Emergency fund: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Sinking funds: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Retirement: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

HOUSING:

Rent/Mortgage: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Utilities: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Phone/Internet: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

FOOD:

Groceries: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Eating out: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TRANSPORTATION:

Gas: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Car payment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Insurance: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

INSURANCE:

Health: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Life: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

PERSONAL:

Clothing: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Personal care: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Entertainment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

DEBT:

Credit card: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Student loan: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Other: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TOTAL EXPENSES: \$ _____ **INCOME - EXPENSES =** \$ _____ (should be \$0)

OCTOBER ZERO-BASED BUDGET

INCOME: \$ _____

GIVING/TITHE:

Tithe: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Charity: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

SAVINGS:

Emergency fund: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Sinking funds: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Retirement: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

HOUSING:

Rent/Mortgage: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Utilities: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Phone/Internet: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

FOOD:

Groceries: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Eating out: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TRANSPORTATION:

Gas: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Car payment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Insurance: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

INSURANCE:

Health: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Life: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

PERSONAL:

Clothing: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Personal care: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Entertainment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

DEBT:

Credit card: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Student loan: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Other: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TOTAL EXPENSES: \$ _____ **INCOME - EXPENSES =** \$ _____ (should be \$0)

NOVEMBER ZERO-BASED BUDGET

INCOME: \$ _____

GIVING/TITHE:

Tithe: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Charity: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

SAVINGS:

Emergency fund: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Sinking funds: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Retirement: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

HOUSING:

Rent/Mortgage: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Utilities: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Phone/Internet: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

FOOD:

Groceries: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Eating out: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TRANSPORTATION:

Gas: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Car payment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Insurance: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

INSURANCE:

Health: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Life: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

PERSONAL:

Clothing: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Personal care: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Entertainment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

DEBT:

Credit card: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Student loan: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Other: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TOTAL EXPENSES: \$ _____ **INCOME - EXPENSES =** \$ _____ (should be \$0)

DECEMBER ZERO-BASED BUDGET

INCOME: \$ _____

GIVING/TITHE:

Tithe: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Charity: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

SAVINGS:

Emergency fund: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Sinking funds: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Retirement: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

HOUSING:

Rent/Mortgage: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Utilities: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Phone/Internet: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

FOOD:

Groceries: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Eating out: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TRANSPORTATION:

Gas: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Car payment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Insurance: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

INSURANCE:

Health: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Life: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

PERSONAL:

Clothing: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Personal care: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Entertainment: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

DEBT:

Credit card: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Student loan: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

Other: Planned \$ _____ Actual \$ _____

TOTAL EXPENSES: \$ _____ **INCOME - EXPENSES =** \$ _____ (should be \$0)

IRREGULAR INCOME PLANNING

If your income varies (freelance, commission, gig work):

STEP 1: List expenses in PRIORITY ORDER

(If you only had \$1000 this month, what gets paid first?)

Priority 1: _____ \$ _____

Priority 2: _____ \$ _____

Priority 3: _____ \$ _____

Priority 4: _____ \$ _____

Priority 5: _____ \$ _____

Priority 6: _____ \$ _____

Priority 7: _____ \$ _____

Priority 8: _____ \$ _____

Priority 9: _____ \$ _____

Priority 10: _____ \$ _____

STEP 2: As income comes in, fund priorities top-down.

Draw a line where the money runs out. Below the line waits.

BUFFER ACCOUNT:

Build a buffer of 1 month's expenses in checking.

This month's income pays NEXT month's budget.

Buffer goal: \$ _____

Current buffer: \$ _____

DEBT SNOWBALL CALCULATOR

List ALL debts smallest to largest balance:

DEBT	BALANCE	MIN PAYMENT	RATE
1. _____	\$ _____	\$ _____	____%
2. _____	\$ _____	\$ _____	____%
3. _____	\$ _____	\$ _____	____%
4. _____	\$ _____	\$ _____	____%
5. _____	\$ _____	\$ _____	____%
6. _____	\$ _____	\$ _____	____%
7. _____	\$ _____	\$ _____	____%

TOTAL DEBT: \$ _____

Total minimum payments: \$ _____

Extra I can throw at debt monthly: \$ _____

SNOWBALL METHOD:

1. Pay minimums on everything
2. Put ALL extra money toward smallest debt
3. When #1 is paid off, roll its payment to #2
4. Keep rolling until all debt is gone!

Estimated debt-free date: _____

MOTIVATION: When I'm debt-free, I will:

EMERGENCY FUND & ANNUAL PLANNING

EMERGENCY FUND TRACKER:

Goal: \$_____ (3-6 months of expenses)

Current balance: \$_____

Monthly contribution: \$_____

Target completion date: _____

ANNUAL EXPENSE PLANNING:

Jan: _____ Jul: _____

Feb: _____ Aug: _____

Mar: _____ Sep: _____

Apr: _____ Oct: _____

May: _____ Nov: _____

Jun: _____ Dec: _____

BUDGET REVIEW & ADJUSTMENT:

What category do I consistently overspend?

Do I need to increase this budget or cut spending?

What category has money left over? Reallocate to:

Remember: A budget is not a cage. It's FREEDOM.

You're telling your money where to go so it stops disappearing.